



AI with **Thiru**

L E A R N · B U I L D · D E P L O Y

AI Video Prompting

The **SCALE** Framework

Five factors sit behind almost every video prompt that works: Subject, Composition, Action, Location, Esthetic. What each one controls, the vocabulary that models actually respond to, and full worked prompts you can adapt tonight.

Subject

Composition

Action

Location

Esthetic

What is SCALE?

SCALE is a five-part checklist for writing a video prompt: Subject, Composition, Action, Location, Esthetic. Most prompts that disappoint are not badly written. They are simply missing one of the five, and the model fills the gap with whatever is most average in its training data.

Name all five and you stop leaving decisions to chance. That is the whole idea.

The five factors

Subject

Who or what are we looking at?

Composition

Where is the camera, and how does it move?

Action

What changes during the clip?

Location

Where does it take place?

Esthetic

How should it look and feel?

Why video is harder than stills: a still image only has to be true for one instant. A video clip has to stay true for every frame. That adds two jobs no image prompt has to do: describe what *changes* (Action), and pin down what must *not* change (Subject and Location, worded identically across shots).

A simple analogy

SCALE is a film crew brief compressed into one sentence. Subject is casting. Composition is the camera department. Action is what the director tells the actor. Location is production design. Esthetic is lighting and the colour grade. Skip one department and the shot still gets made, just not the shot you wanted.

OVERVIEW

The Five at a Glance

Factor	The question it answers	What breaks when you skip it
Subject	Who or what are we looking at?	A generic stand-in that drifts between frames
Composition	Where is the camera, and how does it move?	Flat, arbitrary framing with no motion
Action	What changes during the clip?	A near-still image with wobbling noise
Location	Where does it take place?	A vague backdrop that shifts mid-shot
Esthetic	How should it look and feel?	The default glossy 3D render look

The formula

Write the five in this order. Most engines weight the opening words most heavily, so the subject and the shot type go first.

PROMPT FORMULA.TXT

```
# The shape every prompt in this guide follows
[Composition] of [Subject], [Action], in [Location], [Esthetic]

# Filled in
Slow dolly-in on an elderly watchmaker in a linen apron, lowering a loupe
to his eye, at a cluttered workbench in a narrow Lisbon shop, warm window
light, shot on 35mm film, shallow depth of field
```

One clip, one beat. A generated clip is usually five to ten seconds. That is room for a single action, not a story. Two events in one prompt is the most common reason a model cuts, morphs, or ignores half of what you asked for.

How to use the next five pages

- Each page covers one factor: what it controls, the vocabulary models respond to, and a weak prompt rewritten into a strong one.
- Page 9 assembles complete prompts you can paste straight into a model.
- Page 10 is the fix list for when a clip comes back wrong.

S is for Subject

What it controls: the thing the viewer is meant to watch. Everything else in the frame is context. If the subject is thin, the model invents an average one, and an invented subject is the first thing to morph as the clip runs.

Write it with four handles

Handle	Weak	Strong
Identity	a man	a retired fisherman in his seventies
Wardrobe	wearing a jacket	in a salt-stained yellow oilskin coat
Physicality	tall	broad-shouldered, weathered hands, close-cropped grey beard
Condition	tired	soaked through, breathing hard

Four short handles beat one long adjective pile. Aim for roughly twelve to twenty words on the subject, then stop.

PROMPT SUBJECT.TXT

```
# Weak: the model picks everything, and it will pick differently each frame  
a woman cooking
```

```
# Strong: identity, wardrobe, physicality, condition  
a chef in her forties, tattooed forearms, white jacket rolled to the elbow,  
hair tied back, flour dusting her cheek
```

The consistency trick. When you generate a sequence of shots, paste the subject sentence in *verbatim* every time, word for word. Rewriting it, even into a better sentence, is what makes a face change between shots. Change the camera and the action freely; leave the subject string frozen.

One hero subject per clip. A second person or object competing for attention is better placed in Location, where the model treats it as background.

C is for Composition

What it controls: where the camera sits, what lens it wears, and how it moves. This is the single highest-leverage factor in video, because motion is what separates a clip from a photograph.

Framing and angle

Term	What you get
Extreme close-up	Eyes, hands, texture. Intimate and risky for anatomy
Close-up	Head and shoulders. Emotion
Medium shot	Waist up. The workhorse for dialogue and craft
Wide shot	Full body plus room. Context and scale
Establishing shot	The place first, the subject small inside it
Low or high angle	Looking up gives power, looking down gives vulnerability

Camera movement

- **Static shot** or **locked-off**: no camera motion. The safest choice when the action is complex.
- **Slow dolly in** or **push in**: builds attention. The most reliable move across every model.
- **Tracking shot**: camera travels with a moving subject.
- **Orbit** or **arc**: circles the subject. Great for products, hard on faces.
- **Crane up** or **aerial drone shot**: reveals scale. **Handheld** adds documentary urgency.

One move per clip. A pan and a zoom and an orbit at once produces a nauseous mess, or the model quietly picks one. Choose a single move, then add a lens note.

PROMPT COMPOSITION.TXT

```
# Weak  
nice shot of a car
```

```
# Strong  
low-angle tracking shot, 35mm lens, camera moving alongside at wheel height
```

A is for Action

What it controls: the change that happens inside the clip. Without an explicit action, the model returns something close to a still with a faint drift, which is the most common complaint people have about text-to-video.

Three rules that fix most motion problems

- 1 One beat only.** She lifts the cup. Not: she enters, sits, lifts the cup, and smiles. Split multi-beat ideas into separate clips.
- 2 Use present participles.** Turning, pouring, stepping forward, reaching. This phrasing reads as continuous motion rather than a finished state.
- 3 Name the speed.** Real time, slow motion, or timelapse. Slow motion hides small artifacts and is worth reaching for when hands are in frame.

Secondary motion is what sells it

The main action tells the story, but small ambient movement is what makes a clip read as filmed rather than generated. Add one:

- Steam rising, dust motes in a light beam, embers drifting
- Hair and loose fabric moving in the wind, curtains breathing
- Rain streaking, water rippling, leaves shifting overhead
- Traffic and pedestrians blurring past in the background

PROMPT ACTION.TXT

```
# Weak: a state, not a change. Expect a near-frozen frame.  
a barista standing at an espresso machine  
  
# Strong: one beat, continuous verbs, plus secondary motion  
tamping the portafilter and locking it into the group head in one smooth  
motion, steam curling from the wand behind her, slow motion
```

Skip the dialogue. Text-to-video models do not reliably lip-sync to written lines. Describe the expression and the gesture instead, then add voice in the edit.

L is for Location

What it controls: the world around the subject. Location does more work than people expect, because it silently sets the light, the colour palette, and the sound the viewer imagines.

Build it in three layers

Layer	What to name	Example
Foreground	Something for the camera to pass or shoot through	out-of-focus ferns, a rain-streaked window
Midground	Where the subject stands, and the surface underfoot	a wet cobbled alley, a cluttered workbench
Background	Depth, and something moving in it	neon shopfronts, distant traffic, fog on the hills

Three layers give the model a reason to render real depth, which is what makes a camera move feel three-dimensional rather than like a sliding photograph.

Always set time and weather

- **Time of day** is the cheapest lighting instruction you have. Golden hour, blue hour, harsh noon, and 3am all imply an entire grade.
- **Weather** adds free secondary motion: rain, snow, fog, wind, heat haze.
- **Crowds and traffic** belong here, not in Subject. The model then treats them as texture instead of competing heroes.

PROMPT LOCATION.TXT

```
# Weak  
in a city
```

```
# Strong: three layers, time, weather  
in a narrow Tokyo alley at night, out-of-focus izakaya lanterns in the  
foreground, wet asphalt reflecting neon, light rain, steam venting from  
a grate in the background
```

E is for Esthetic

What it controls: the finish. Two clips can share a subject, a camera move, an action, and a location, and still feel like a phone video or a feature film. Esthetic is the difference, and it is the factor people most often leave off.

Four dials worth naming

Dial	Options that work
Lighting	soft overcast, hard directional sun, rim light, neon practicals, candlelight, volumetric god rays
Colour	warm amber grade, teal and orange, desaturated, high contrast black and white, pastel
Medium	shot on 35mm film, 16mm grain, anamorphic flare, vintage VHS, crisp digital
Mood	melancholic, tense, serene, nostalgic, clinical

Name a genre, not a living artist. "In the style of a 1970s crime thriller" gives the model a rich, unambiguous target. Naming a living director or photographer is vaguer than it sounds, and it carries licensing and attribution problems you do not want on commercial work.

PROMPT ESTHETIC.TXT

```
# Weak
cinematic, high quality, 4k, masterpiece

# Strong: lighting, colour, medium, mood
low-key rim lighting, desaturated teal grade, shot on 16mm with visible
grain, tense and claustrophobic
```

Quality-word stacking such as `4k masterpiece ultra detailed` is a habit carried over from early image models. It costs you prompt weight and buys very little. Spend those words on lighting instead.

PRACTICE

Three Complete Prompts

All five factors, assembled in order. Paste any of these into a text-to-video model and swap the details for your own.

PROMPT 01_CHARACTER.TXT

```
# Cinematic character shot
Slow dolly-in, 85mm lens, on a retired fisherman in his seventies wearing a
salt-stained yellow oilskin, weathered hands gripping a mug, lifting his eyes
to the window as steam curls past his face, in the galley of a small trawler
at dawn, condensation on the porthole, grey sea rolling behind him, soft blue
hour light, muted colour grade, shot on 35mm film, quiet and reflective
```

PROMPT 02_PRODUCT.TXT

```
# Product shot
Slow 180-degree orbit, macro lens, around a brushed titanium watch resting on
black slate, second hand sweeping, a single drop of water sliding down the
crystal, in a dark studio with one soft key light from the left, deep shadow
falling away behind, high contrast, crisp digital, clean and premium
```

PROMPT 03_NATURE.TXT

```
# Nature documentary
Static wide shot, 24mm lens, of a red fox standing alert in knee-high frosted
grass, ears turning toward a sound off-frame before it steps forward, in an
open meadow at first light, mist pooling in the hollows, pine treeline behind,
low golden sun raking across the frost, natural colour, shot on 16mm with
gentle grain, patient and observational
```

Negative prompts, if your model supports them. Keep one short reusable list rather than writing a new one each time: warped hands, extra fingers, distorted face, morphing, flickering, text, watermark, jump cut .

When a Clip Comes Back Wrong

What you are seeing	The usual cause and fix
Barely any movement	No Action. Add a continuous verb, plus one camera move
The face or object changes mid-clip	Subject is under-described. Add wardrobe and physicality, and shorten the clip
The camera does something you did not ask for	Competing move words. Keep exactly one
It cuts to a different scene	You described two beats. Split it into two clips
Hands and fingers are mangled	Pull back to a medium or wide shot, or shoot the action in slow motion
It looks like a glossy 3D render	No Esthetic. Name the lighting, the grade, and the medium
Signs and labels are gibberish	Do not ask for readable text. Add it in the edit instead
Shots in a sequence do not match	The subject string was reworted. Paste it in identically every time

Before you hit generate

- Can you point to all five factors in your prompt? Missing one is the default failure.
- Is there exactly one action beat and exactly one camera move?
- Would two different readers picture the same subject? If not, add a handle.
- Have you named the light? Time of day alone will often do it.
- Generate three or four takes of a good prompt before rewriting it. Most models are stochastic enough that the prompt was fine and the seed was not.

RECAP

SCALE, in One View

A final summary you can keep beside the prompt box. Each factor in one sentence, in the order you should write them.

S Subject

Who or what we watch, in twelve to twenty words: identity, wardrobe, physicality, condition. Paste it in verbatim across a sequence.

C Composition

Framing, angle, lens, and exactly one camera move. The highest-leverage factor, because motion is what makes it a video.

A Action

One beat, written with continuous verbs, at a named speed, with a touch of secondary motion to sell it.

L Location

Foreground, midground, background, plus time of day and weather. This is where your crowds and your free lighting live.

E Esthetic

Lighting, colour, medium, mood. Four real dials are worth more than a pile of quality words.



Thanks for reading

AI WITH THIRU

If this guide helped, subscribe to **AI with Thiru** for more hands-on AI, machine learning, and LLM tutorials. Try it tonight: write one prompt with all five factors, then delete a single factor and run it again. The gap between those two clips is the whole framework in one experiment.